



Policy

Testing Mental Health Inpatients for Alcohol and / or illicit Substance Use and / or Medications not Prescribed by the Treating Team

Policy code	EMHS: 151
Original endorsement date	July 2016
Date of current endorsement	October 2022
Version	1.0
Functional subgroup	Mental Health
Summary	The use of alcohol and / or illicit substance and / or medications not prescribed by the treating team by a mental health inpatient of the East Metropolitan Health Services (EMHS) is not permitted. If there is reasonable concern that an inpatient has consumed alcohol and / or illicit substance, the in-patient can be requested to submit to an appropriate test.
Policy owner	Executive Director Clinical Service Planning and Population Health
Contact	Area manager Mental Health
Review date	October 2025
NSQHS Standards (second edition)	Clinical Governance; Comprehensive Care; Communicating for Safety; Recognising and responding to acute deterioration
NSMHS	1.1, 1.3, 8.8, 8.9
Status	Active



1. Background

1.1. About this document

The use of alcohol and / or illicit substance and / or medications not prescribed by the treating team by a mental health inpatient of the East Metropolitan Health Services (EMHS) is not permitted. If there is reasonable concern that an inpatient has consumed alcohol and / or illicit substance, the in-patient can be requested to submit to an appropriate test.

2. Testing Mental Health Inpatients for Alcohol or Illegal Drug Use

Patients will be informed at the point of admission or the earliest opportunity that the use of alcohol and / or illicit substances and / or medications not prescribed by the treating team will not be tolerated.

Refer to the EMHS [Alcohol and Prohibited Substances policy](#).

Testing may be undertaken in situations where there is a strong suspicion of alcohol / illicit substance use and where such use could impact on the patient's mental state or could compromise the patient's treatment plan.

All EMHS Mental Health services are to develop protocols and procedures, as required.

3. Consent

Only patients who give their informed consent may be tested.

- An explanation of the reason for the testing must be given to the patient (including potential treatment outcomes).
- The patient has the right to refuse to be tested.
- The patient's consent must be obtained prior to testing for alcohol and / or illicit substance use.

Refer to the Department of Health (DoH) Operational Directive [OD0657/16 WA Health Consent to Treatment Policy 2016](#)

4. Consultation

Relevant medical staff must be involved in the decision making process regarding testing the patient.

The patient's doctor or the Duty Medical Officer may be consulted about the perceived need for requesting the patient to submit to testing.

5. Where Patient Refuses

If the patient refuses to be tested, the patient's behaviour, demeanour and actions will be accurately documented and discussed with the treating team, a decision may be made on the patient's presentation that there is a strong likelihood of intoxication.

The treating team is to discuss the patient's behaviour, demeanour and actions.

In the absence of objective proof of intoxication but if it was felt that there is a strong likelihood of intoxication, then refer to the local protocols and procedures.

6. Training

Staff administering tests for the presence of alcohol or illicit substances must have received adequate instruction in the correct administration of the test and interpretation of the results.

Only staff who have been trained in the use of the equipment are to conduct the testing.

7. Equipment

Equipment for testing will be correctly stored and maintained.

Equipment for testing of patients, for the presence of alcohol or illicit substances is to only be accessible through the Senior Nurse or the Duty Medical Officer).

EMHS Health Technology Management has the responsibility maintenance of alcohol analysers used for testing of patients; the equipment must be registered on a data base maintained by EMHS Health Technology Management.

A certificate of correct calibration will be provided to the clinical unit by EMHS Health Technology Management.

All items of alcohol testing equipment are to receive a routine maintenance inspection twice yearly.

8. Documentation

Documentation must be completed in the patient health record when there is reasonable concern that an inpatient has consumed alcohol and / or illicit substance and / or medications not prescribed by the treating team.

The following must be fully documented in the patient's health record:

- The circumstances leading to the request for testing,
- The consultation with the medical staff;
- The explanation to the patient;

- Their consent (or refusal);
- The testing and results; and
- Review of the management care plan, including any requirements for withdrawal management

9. Incident Reporting

Documentation for incident reporting must comply with Department of Health policy. Refer to the DoH MP0122/19 [Clinical Incident Management Policy 2019](#)

A clinical incident is to be notified using the WA Health Datix Clinical Incident Management System (CIMS).

10. Compliance monitoring and legislative penalties

10.1. Compliance monitoring

Each EMHS site or service executive director is to ensure compliance with this policy.

Compliance monitoring methods include:

- Number of nurses and medical officers trained in the use and testing of the relevant equipment.

10.2. Legislative obligations

There are no legislative obligations relating to this policy for which a statutory penalty is imposed for a breach.

11. Legislation

- Mental Health Act 1996

12. Additional references

12.1. Department of Health policies

- DoH Operational Directive 0657/16 WA Health Consent to Treatment Policy.
- DoH Operational Directive MP0122/19 Clinical Incident Management Policy (2015)

12.2. EMHS policies

- EMHS Alcohol and Illicit Substances policy